ALWAYS FALLING

A 3D anime short about distance, a promise, and India's first satellite

Team FirstCommit
Team lead: **Mohammad Umar**
Members: Bilal Feroz, Fuad Ahamed
DADC Short Film Festival 2026 · Theme: **Gravity**
Runtime 5:00 · 1920×1080 · 24 fps · Hindi/Urdu with English subtitles

SYNOPSIS

Hyderabad, April 1975. The week India launches its first satellite, Aryabhata, a father leaves the Old City for the building sites of Abu Dhabi. On their last night on the rooftop he explains orbits to his five-year-old son: a satellite is always falling toward the Earth, but it moves so fast that it keeps missing. Always falling toward home, and always missing. He makes a promise: every night when it passes, they will both look up.

Aryabhata's instruments fail after four days, but it keeps circling. The screen splits, Hyderabad on the left and Abu Dhabi on the right, and only the satellite's dot crosses the divide. Letters, a two-rupee note and cassette tapes cross the sea while the gap between father and son grows wider. In 1981 the satellite falls silent, and so does the last tape.

February 1992. After seventeen years and 92,000 orbits, Aryabhata comes home as a fireball that burns through the divide. The grown son looks up from the rooftop, and in the lane below stands his father, suitcase in hand. "Abba." He is home, and the promise was kept: every night, both of them had looked up.

HOW THE THEME LIVES IN THE FILM

Gravity is the story's physics and its feeling. An orbit is a fall that never lands: the father's explanation of Newton's cannon becomes the shape of his life abroad, close enough to circle and too fast to come down. The split screen makes the invisible pull visible. The divider widens with every year, and only gravity's messenger, the satellite, crosses it until re-entry finally lets it fall.

PROCESS

- Fully 3D, rendered in **Blender 5.1 (EEVEE)** through a custom anime pipeline written in Python: cel shading, ink outlines and animation "on twos". In post: impact frames, manga focus lines, a panel-slam montage, speed lines, light sweeps for time jumps, god rays and bloom.
- Characters built on **MPFB/MakeHuman** base meshes (CC0), with hand-coded garments, hair and anime eyes. A scripted **facial-expression system** (brows, lids, mouth, blinks, lip-sync, tears, eye sparkles) is keyed to every story beat on an acting sheet.
- Procedural sets: Hyderabad Old City with the Charminar skyline; 1970s Abu Dhabi construction sites; the Kosmos-3M launch; Earth from orbit from NASA Blue/Black Marble maps (public domain); a 92,000-orbit "cocoon"; the re-entry plasma.
- **Split-screen grammar:** cool Hyderabad on the left, warm Abu Dhabi on the right. The divider grows over 17 years and burns away at re-entry.
- A **life pass** keeps nobody a statue (breathing, idle motion, a handheld camera, depth of field on close-ups), and a **set pass** paints variation and contact shadows into every surface.
- **Sound:** an original score played with recorded orchestral samples (upright piano "promise" motif, strings, glockenspiel, bass drum) over a tanpura drone; ambiences and foley are real recordings. Stereo follows the split: Hyderabad left, Abu Dhabi right. Voices are processed as a rooftop, a radio and cassette tape.

HISTORY & LICENCE

Launch	19 April 1975, Kosmos-3M from Kapustin Yar (USSR)
Failure	Power failure after 4 days in orbit; experiments halted
Silence	Mainframe signals until March 1981
Re-entry	February 1992, after about 17 years in orbit
₹2 note	Aryabhata was pictured on India's two-rupee note; the film shows a stylised, non-replica design
Poetic licence	The family is fictional. The visibility of the re-entry over Hyderabad and the orbit count shown are dramatised.

Content: no smoking, alcohol or violence. The film depicts Hyderabad and the UAE with respect.

AI USE DECLARATION

This film used AI tools extensively, and we declare all of it:

- **Concept and script:** developed with **Claude** (Anthropic), **ChatGPT** (OpenAI) and **Gemini** (Google) as brainstorming and critique partners. The team chose the story, setting, language and final creative direction.
- **Production code:** the Blender scene, character, animation, facial-expression, compositing and audio scripts were written by **Claude** (an AI coding assistant) under the team's direction. All frames were rendered locally from these 3D scenes.
- **Voices:** AI text-to-speech, **Microsoft neural voices**: Hindi "Madhur" (the father), Urdu "Salman" (the son), Hindi "Swara" (the 1992 radio news) and Indian-English "Prabhat" (the ground station). Earlier drafts used Piper.
- **Critique:** ChatGPT and Gemini were shown stills from the film for feedback during refinement.
- **Not used:** no generative image or video models created any frame. Every image is rendered 3D geometry. The Earth maps are NASA photographs, processed with conventional image filters.

Third-party assets: MPFB/MakeHuman assets (CC0); NASA Blue Marble and Black Marble imagery (public domain); fonts IBM Plex Mono, Shippori Mincho and Noto Sans (SIL Open Font License); VS Chamber Orchestra 2: Community Edition samples (CC0, Versilian Studios; upright piano by Simon Dalzell / Ivy Audio); CC0 field recordings from Freesound (full list with authors in the project repository). The score is composed for this film; drones and some effects are synthesised in code.

CREDITS

Written, directed and produced by Team FirstCommit: **Mohammad Umar** (team lead), **Bilal Feroz** and **Fuad Ahamed**. Made for the DADC Short Film Festival 2026, IIT Delhi Abu Dhabi.